Two outbound numbers that were wrong, and how they got fixed

Matthias Neumann · UnpauseAI · November 2026

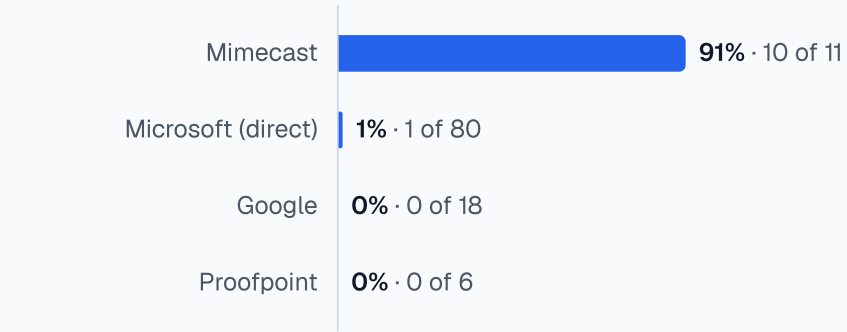
UnpauseAI

1 Bounces an email verifier can't see

UK events company, corporate cold outreach, July 2026

128 first emails went out. Every address was marked "valid" by NeverBounce and sender authentication was in place, yet the batch bounced far above normal.

Bounce rate by the recipient's mail server



The other 13 sends went to smaller mail servers; none bounced.

The addresses were fine. Mimecast, a security gateway in front of the recipient's mailbox, refused the mail. A verifier checks that a mailbox exists; it cannot see the gateway.

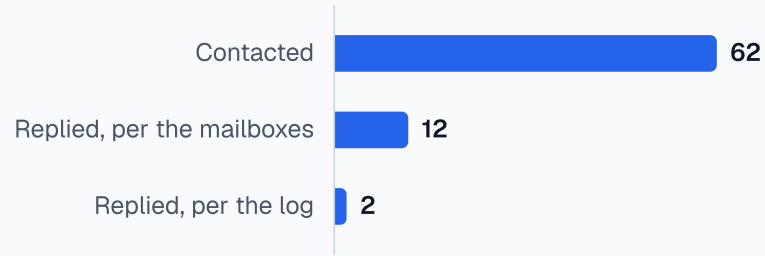
> **Fix:** look up each domain's mail server (MX) before a lead is loaded, and hold Mimecast and no-MX domains out of the email send. It now runs on every load: 12 leads held out of the October wave, 63 out of November's.

2 Replies the log never saw

Treasury-software company, conference follow-up, September 2026

A report to the client listed 62 people contacted across three waves. Checked against the two mailboxes, 12 of them had written back. The log held 2 of those replies.

Replies found, by source



The log only knew about replies the live inbox poll caught. Anything it missed was never picked up afterwards.

> **Fix:** a daily scan re-reads inbound mail from every folder of both mailboxes and reconciles it with the log. Out-of-office replies cannot move a contact's stage. The first runs recovered real replies the tool had never held, and the client report now re-checks at render time whether anyone on it has answered since.

In both cases the dashboard number was confident and wrong. Before tuning an agent on a metric, I check the metric against the source.

Clients anonymized. Figures from the campaign records.